

DecisionBrief — Conversation Transcript

Scenario: choose-crm • Residential Plumbing + HVAC + Electrical • 4,200 Customers • Housecall Pro + QBO

2026-05-14 09:42 AM

DecisionBrief: Choosing a CRM? Tell me a bit about your business and your role today?

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You: I'm owner of a residential home services company — plumbing, HVAC, and electrical, 3 trades under one brand. 18 techs, 3 office, 2 sales guys for HVAC replacements. I do ops and sales oversight. We're in Houston suburbs.

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DecisionBrief: Got it — 3 trades, 23 people, owner-operator in Houston. How do you track customers and jobs today?

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You: Housecall Pro for dispatch and invoicing, QuickBooks Online for books, and spreadsheets for everything else. Housecall has customer records but no real sales pipeline. If a tech does a plumbing repair and sees old HVAC, there's no cross-sell tracked. No customer lifetime view across trades.

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DecisionBrief: Understood — Housecall Pro is your workhorse but not a CRM, and cross-sell across trades is invisible. What volume of customers and leads are you seeing?

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You: About 4,200 active customers in Housecall, 300 new leads a month — Google Ads, Angi, and referrals. HVAC installs are 25 a month at \$8k-15k each, that's our margin driver. Plumbing and electrical are high frequency but smaller tickets, \$250-\$600. We have 600 maintenance plans at \$180/yr and churn is killing us because no one follows up for renewal.

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DecisionBrief: That's rich — 4,200 actives, 300 new leads/mo, 25 HVAC installs, 600 maintenance plans with renewal churn. What systems have you tried before for sales and support?

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You: Tried Jobber 2 years ago for 6 months — great for single trade but broke when we added electrical. Tried HubSpot free CRM last year, but techs never used it, double entry with Housecall, and office hated switching tabs. Went back to spreadsheets for follow-ups, which means no follow-up.

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DecisionBrief: Got it — Jobber too single-trade, HubSpot too detached from dispatch causing double entry. What must a CRM actually do for you to be worth paying for?

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You: Single customer view across all 3 trades — history, equipment, warranty, what we quoted vs sold. Sales pipeline for HVAC installs with stages, financing, and close reasons. Service ticket view for callbacks and warranty, so we stop losing money on free return trips. Maintenance plan tracking — when it expires, who owns it, renewal automation via text/email. And texting that techs will actually use from the field.

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DecisionBrief: Clear — single customer view across trades, install pipeline with financing and loss reasons, callback/warranty ticket tracking, maintenance plan renewal automation, and field-friendly texting. What about integrations and budget?

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You: Must sync with Housecall Pro and QuickBooks Online without double entry — if we have to enter twice, it dies. QuickBooks for invoices, Housecall for jobs. Under \$400/month all-in for 5 office/sales seats, techs don't need seats if they can text via mobile app. Needs onboarding — my office staff is not tech savvy and we can't have a 3-month implementation.

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DecisionBrief: Understood — Housecall + QBO sync, <\$400/mo for 5 seats, mobile texting for techs, real onboarding, not self-serve videos. What constraints or blackout times?

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You: Can't switch during summer peak June-August, that's HVAC install season — we will lose jobs if systems break. Also need to migrate 2 years of customer history, equipment, and open estimates — about 1,100 open estimates sitting in Housecall. Need to keep dispatch running, this is CRM addition not dispatch replacement.

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DecisionBrief: Got it — no go-live June-Aug, keep Housecall as dispatch, migrate 2 years history + 1,100 open estimates. What worries you most about adding a CRM?

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You: Techs won't use it — they already hate Housecall notes, if CRM adds steps they will ignore it. Also losing track of callbacks — we eat cost on warranty returns because we can't link original job to callback. And if Google Ads leads don't auto-flow into CRM, front desk forgets to follow up in 10 minutes and we lose \$12k jobs.

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DecisionBrief: Thanks — field adoption, callback cost leakage, and lead response speed are key risks. If this works, what does success look like in 6 months?

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You: Every customer has one record with all 3 trades, equipment, and last 2 years history. 25 HVAC installs a month tracked to lead source with close reasons, not gut feel. Callbacks tracked to original job with cost, so we know which tech or install crew is burning us. Maintenance plans renewal rate from 62% to 85% with automated text. And repeat customer rate across trades up 20% because we finally cross-sell plumbing when we do HVAC.

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DecisionBrief: I have enough information to prepare your Decision Brief.

Anonymous session • No login • No database • Server memory only • Session discarded after completion